

HORNILLS, HOOPOES, AND WOOD HOOPOES

Hornbills (including some giants of the bird world), hoopoes, wood hoopoes, and the similar scimitarbills form an Old World order, the Bucerotiformes, some boldly coloured and all strikingly patterned and distinctive in form.

Hoopoes walk on the ground and probe for invertebrates and small reptiles with their slender,

curved bill, while wood hoopoes hop on trees and probe inside loose bark. Hornbills have a larger, longer bill, some with a large, horny adornment on top. They range from medium-sized to very large forest species. Ground hornbills are extremely large, heavy birds that feed exclusively on the ground. Some hornbills nest in tree holes and males seal the females inside with mud, feeding them through a narrow slit until the young hatch.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	BUCEROTIFORMES
FAMILIES	4
SPECIES	74

42–45 cm
16½–18 in

grey, white, and
black plumage

RED-BILLED HORNBILL

Tockus erythrorhynchus
F: Bucerotidae

Tockus hornbills are small African predators, most with a red or yellow bill. This species inhabits savanna and open woodland from Senegal to Namibia.

white
underparts

reddish bill

TRUMPETER HORNBILL

Bycanistes bucinator
F: Bucerotidae

This hornbill inhabits the forests of eastern to southern Africa. It is similar to the related silvery-cheeked hornbill, but has red facial skin.

58–65 cm
23–26 in

75–80 cm
30–32 in

SILVERY-CHEEKED HORNBILL

Bycanistes brevis
F: Bucerotidae

This fruit-eating pied hornbill is a forest species from E. Africa. As with other hornbills, the male has a larger bill than the female, with a more prominent casque.

ORIENTAL PIED HORNBILL

Anthraceros albirostris
F: Bucerotidae

The most widespread of the Asian pied hornbills, this bird occurs from the Himalayas to Bali (Indonesia), in cultivated land as well as forest.

70 cm
28 in

1 m
3¾ in

70 cm
28 in

25–32 cm
10–12½ in

black-tipped
crest, raised
when landing

black and
white bars
on wings

NORTHERN GROUND HORNBILL

Bucorvus abyssinicus
F: Bucorvidae

One of two predatory ground hornbills of African grasslands, this species from Senegal to Kenya tolerates drier conditions than its southern counterpart.

Upupa epops
F: Upupidae

This species nests in tree-holes in Africa and Eurasia. It has a flickering, butterfly-like flight and a strong bill to dig for ground-living invertebrates.

**MALABAR PIED
HORNBILL**
Anthraceros coronatus
F: Bucerotidae

Like most other Asian hornbills, this pied species from India and Sri Lanka is omnivorous, and eats a great deal of fruit.

**GREEN
WOOD HOOPOE**
Phoeniculus purpureus
F: Phoeniculidae

This African wood hoopoe climbs trees like a woodpecker, but has a hoopoe-like bill to probe rotting wood for invertebrates.